

Episode 135: Once Upon a Time... 79 – 1994 Part 13 – What! A Religious Organisation's OVA *Warriors of Erosion*

I went to Hong Kong at summer's end. I go to Hong Kong for fun fairly regularly, but this was my first time during such obviously hot midsummer season. I went quite prepared, but huh? Totally fine somehow. Rather, cool?

Apparently this year's Japan, particularly Tokyo's intense heat and extreme heat, secretly gave us heat tolerance? (wry laugh)

Ah, but checking temperatures, ah, Hong Kong was indeed somewhat cooler (wry laugh). At least mornings and evenings, temperatures properly dropped. Really, Japan being hotter than tropical Hong Kong...

Now then.

Sailor Moon S movie, fighting various blues. That autumn-winter of 1994, I was also participating in another work in parallel. An OVA called *Warriors of Erosion*.

Staff included Director: Kasai Osamu, Setting: Tsunoda Koichi, Character Design & Animation Director: Nashizawa Takashi, Art Directors: Uchikawa Fumihiko & Tokushige Masaru. And colour design by me (credited as "colour direction").

This was actually a commissioned work from a certain religious organisation in Hiroshima Prefecture. One of the so-called "religious anime," perhaps? When first told about this job by my supervisor, I thought "Huh?" "What kind of thing will we make?"

But I thought it seemed somewhat interesting. I heard it wasn't something containing that religious organisation's doctrine, but rather "human history is religious history," and "easy-to-understand world religious history digest" with "ultimately religion saves humanity's future!" to teach their believers in an understandable way. Basically a video

work just for distribution within that organisation. For me, this "easy-to-understand world religious history digest" aspect seemed interesting. So I decided to participate.

Anyway, since it's anime never commercially released, explanation and description are difficult... but somewhere in the vast universe beyond there's a place called Nakoku Tsunedokoro where the head god resides, and a novice god boy who caused some mischief there gets dropped to a star called "Punishment Country" (Earth) as punishment. That novice boy, together with two little demons turned into snakes by god, follows human and religious history on Earth throughout.

My work was the same as usual. First deciding main character colours. "Novice boy" and his pet that understands human language, plus snake versions and original versions of the two little demons—these were main characters. Everything else had just scattered character designs, with almost everything being key animation matching!

Actually, as the story progressed, scenes kept changing constantly, and Moses, Christ, Buddha, Nichiren appeared for maybe 10 cuts each at most. I created colours for these named religious figures from main feature cuts for checking, then proceeded mostly with reference matching. Not photographs as reference, but paintings and religious paintings from those periods, or imagination-type materials as basis for both animation and painting.

For example, Moses work matched good-atmosphere paintings drawn by later generations. Opposing Egyptian soldiers used materials selected from other reference collections matching the period. Right, as much as possible, historical research—or period clothing and such—we gathered references and researched for matching.

But this was quite fun. Since animation drew fairly solidly according to references, adding colours with reference matching naturally fit well! Doing such things feels quite good. Plus I personally like history, so I could work with enjoyment creating such ancient period things on screen.

Plus proper drama was created, so night scenes, bonfire scenes, early morning atmosphere scenes—quite a lot of special painting too. Actually the parallel *Sailor Moon S* movie was designed with as many "normal" colour scenes as possible, so partly in reaction, I enjoyed changing colours scene by scene, cut by cut, doing whatever I wanted (laugh).

The story moves significantly from when Nostradamus prophesies humanity's future disasters. From the "three cart fire house" parable, it advances to parables like "socialism," "free prosperity ideology," "science technology faith ideology," and religion extends salvation to humanity facing destruction reality (wry laugh).

This climax "three carts pulled by sheep, deer, and cattle" scene resembled theatrical *Utena*'s climax, and the salvation ship descending from the sky at the end was quite Matsumoto Reiji-like sci-fi, with dynamics that quite hit my sweet spot (laugh).

Such was *Warriors of Erosion* (laugh).

Fortunately I received a sample VHS of the completed product. Not a so-called "white box" but proper packaged product. How many were actually manufactured? Being an extremely small-scale work from 15-16 years ago, I have the impression that probably nobody has this footage anymore.

Actually anime isn't just TV and theatrical—quite a lot of such works are made. Things commissioned by various organisations like this, school education-related works like those placed in libraries nationwide.

So while "anime halls" and such "buildings" are inexcusable, creating archives of anime that don't appear much before general audiences would be quite meaningful, I think.

(10.09.08)